dealings. Its deposits and investments grew and one of its ‘firsts’ in Punjab was a Safe Deposit Vault. By June 1927, the Bank had opened branches at Ahmedabad, Amritsar, Asansol, Calcutta, Kanpur, Chandausi, New Delhi, Hapur, Hyderabad, (Deccan) Jharia, Karachi, Kasur, Lahore, Lucknow, Lyallpur, Madras, Rangoon, and Secunderabad.[5] Insofar as UP was concerned the Central Bank had established thirteen branches by 1935.

Several states also invited Sorabji to open branches, among them being Nawanagar where the Jam Saheb regarded the Central Bank as the most ‘reliable and enterprising’ among Indian banks. The Jamnagar branch was inaugurated on March 27, 1937, just a few months before Sorabji passed away. The bank had a monopoly in Nawanagar. Another state where the Central Bank played a major role was Hyderabad where apart from opening branches it also subscribed to ₹1.3 crores of a ₹4 crore loan floated by the Nizam’s government. It also helped the state in replacing the British rupee with the Osman Shahi rupee. The bank also played a pioneering role in advancing loans for house-building purposes in Hyderabad.

Branches were also opened in Cochin not only to promote trade, but also to develop the Cochin harbour. The bank also acted as bankers for the state and successfully floated loans for the governments of Travancore and Bhopal. At that time the banking scene in south India was cluttered with a large number of small banks, most of which failed in the manner of the Travancore National Bank. The field was open for the Central Bank to take advantage of this opportunity and rapid progress was achieved under the overall management of B.T. Thakur, one of Sorabji’s trusted associates, who subsequently became the first General Manager of the United Commercial Bank with G.D. Birla as its Chairman.

Numerous branches in different areas demanded close attention to local conditions and Sorabji had to evolve suitable machinery to manage these without undue interference from the headquarters. While a Branches Inspection Department with a team of itinerant auditors was in place, Sorabji also pioneered the system of Local Boards or Local Advisory Committees consisting of prominent local merchants and public leaders who would provide information on the creditworthiness of borrowers and thus safeguard the bank’s interests. They possessed an intimate knowledge of local conditions and benefited the management of the bank by making available their knowledge of local conditions. This was all the more useful